1

THE PAKISTANI JIHADI MILIEU

Storming the World Stage seeks to explain to the reader Lashkar-e-Taiba, not Pakistan, but exploring the former's evolution is impossible without addressing some of the centrifugal forces that shaped the latter's development.

Pakistan has faced serious domestic and foreign challenges during its short history. These, in turn, influenced the country's engagement with Islamist parties and militants, and thus the jihadi milieu in which Lashkar developed. There are several ways to comprehend the dynamics of jihadism in Pakistan during Lashkar's early years. One is to distinguish militant groups based on their Islamic school of thought, with the major players representing the Deobandi and Ahl-e-Hadith sects of Islam. Another is to situate a jihadi group's focus of activity, to the extent possible, in one of three theaters: Afghanistan; Indian-administered Kashmir; and sectarianism in Pakistan.[1] These loci were never discrete and have shifted of late, while former divisions between Deobandi militants and the Ahl-e-Hadith Lashkar became less marked over time as well. Nevertheless, these categories remain useful analytic tools for situating Lashkar during its formative years, and are explored below. Before doing so, this chapter first provides a broad overview of Pakistan's history from the Partition of British India to its participation as a US ally in the Afghan jihad against the Soviets.[2]

Pakistan was created via partition from India in 1947 as a home for South Asia's Muslims. Like other countries that brought together disparate ethnicities as the colonial era came to a close, Pakistan became a state before it was a nation. Unlike other post-colonial countries, which were created as the result of self-determination movements, Pakistan was not born in a struggle against colonial rule. Rather it was formed in opposition